

Gossip: The Social Glue [B1]

Il pettegolezzo non è certo un'abitudine dei giorni nostri: ce lo dimostra l'origine della parola 'gossip'.

Sometimes, over time, a word loses its original positive meaning and gradually takes on a negative one. How does this happen? A good example is the word 'gossip', which today often has a negative connotation. 'Gossip' comes from 'godsibb', an Old English term made up of 'god' and 'sibb' meaning 'relationship' or 'affinity'. It referred to a relative connected, not by blood, but spiritually through God. In the Middle Ages, godsibs were the godfathers and godmothers present at a baptism. Their role was to support the biological family and they represented close friendship, trust and care. At the time, these relationships were strong bonds, socially significant and in some cases even legally binding.

WOMEN'S SPEECH

In the late Middle Ages and during the Renaissance, the term began to refer to trusted female members of the community who assisted women during childbirth. They were close friends of the family and spent a great deal of time with them, talking freely about everything and sharing news, stories, and secrets. Between the 14th and 15th centuries, the word 'godsibb' was shortened to 'gossip', and its meaning gradually shifted from referring to a person to describing a type of behaviour, that is, instead of a trusted intimate person, it referred to informal conversation engaged in by a talkative companion.

USELESS TALK

Between the 16th and 17th centuries, 'gossip' began to acquire a derogatory meaning and became associated with women's domestic talk and engagement in conversations considered pointless or trivial. Women's words were increasingly devalued, especially in contrast to male-dominated written

and institutional discourse. The opposition between oral and written communication became sharper and reflected the widening gap between private and public spheres. Language

Small Talk is Great Alla macchinetta del caffè o con il passeggero che ci è seduto accanto in aereo: una chiacchiera, seppur superficiale, aiuta a creare un'intesa. Daniel Francis

GENDERED

For centuries, gossip was closely connected to gender and was often dismissed. Its shift from a word about trust and care to one about socially reprehensible behaviour isn't just a linguistic change, but also reflects a broader social and cultural transformation. Women and the lower social classes were associated with 'inferior' oral, informal and non-institutional language. Such attitudes stigmatised and delegitimised certain groups, reflecting imbalances of power.

SOCIAL GLUE

Today, linguistics and sociology often re-evaluate gossip as social glue through which relational bonds are formed, moral values are shared and group identity reinforced. This function is often compared to social grooming in primates.

GOSSIP, RUMOUR OR HEARSAY?

Gossip usually focuses on people, their behaviours and relationships. The word 'rumour', instead, refers primarily to events or facts whose truth is uncertain. 'Hearsay' is a more formal term, mainly used in legal contexts. It describes information learned through others, without direct evidence, and is often not accepted as evidence in a court of law.

GOSSIP IN LITERATURE

Gossip plays an important role in literature, where it often becomes a narrative engine. In William Shakespeare, the word 'gossip' still means 'godmother' or 'close female friend', but it already suggests the idea of indiscreet talk. This shows a moment of transition in meaning. Shakespeare uses gossip in a strikingly modern way: the plot in *Othello* or *Much Ado About Nothing*, for example, develops around the circulation of gossip that anticipates what we would now call disinformation or an early form of fake news, with the aim of insinuating, suggesting and manipulating. Jane Austen is also a master in the use of gossip to move the plot. In novels such as *Pride and Prejudice* or *Emma*, the gossip circulating in small, closed social circles shapes reputations and strongly influences marriages or social exclusion. In Oscar Wilde, on the other hand, moral judgment is reversed: gossip is presented as entertainment and social performance, exposing the hypocrisy of Victorian society. Silence means invisibility, and visibility means power. This theme is embodied in his novel *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, where the character Lord Henry Wotton asserts: "The only thing worse than being talked about is not being talked about."

Glossary

- **aim** = obiettivo
- **shapes** = modellare
- **pointless** = futile
- **embodied** = incarnare, personificare
- **asserts** = affermare, sostenere
- **over time** = col passare del tempo
- **godfathers and godmothers** = padrini e madrine
- **a great deal** = una grande quantità
- **talkative** = loquace, chiacchierone
- **derogatory** = peggiorativo, dispregiativo
- **glue** = collante
- **grooming** = toelettatura, pulizia sociale (etologia)
- **bonds** = legami
- **legally binding** = legalmente vincolante
- **engaged in** = partecipare a
- **sharper** = più marcato
- **dismissed** = sminuire
- **Hearsay** = voci di corridoio, testimonianza per sentito dire
- **court of law** = tribunale
- **move the plot** = far avanzare la trama
- **trust** = fiducia
- **shifted** = cambiare
- **widening gap** = divario crescente
- **reprehensible behaviour** = comportamento riprovevole
- **strikingly** = sorprendentemente
- **Much Ado About Nothing** = "Molto rumore per nulla"